were a defense against another U.S. invasion, and the U.S. insistence that it remain the only nuclear power in the hemisphere just another example of imperial arrogance. The "crisis," from the Cuban perspective, was not the presence of the missiles, but the arbitrary U.S. decision to challenge the Soviets to a nuclear war.

Figure 3.1 Billboard near Playa Girón. "Girón: First Defeat of Yankee Imperialism in Latin America"

Source: Photo by Tracey Eaton



From a larger Latin American perspective, the Bay of Pigs is just one in a long, dreary list of U.S. invasions and occupations of their countries, largely unknown in the United States itself. These include, since 1898, the numerous troop landings in Cuba; the lengthy occupations of Nicaragua, Haiti, and the Dominican Republic; the 1954 overthrow of the Arbenz government in Guatemala; counterinsurgencies and "low intensity conflicts" in Central America in the 1980s; and so on. The only thing that makes the Bay of Pigs unique is that the invasion did not succeed.

Planning for the Bay of Pigs invasion started as early as March 1960, when the Revolution was just over a year old. Many studies have recounted the precise course of events of the invasion. Here, we will try to place it in context by asking: How did the actions of Cuba's revolutionary leaders affect the country's relationship with the United States? How did U.S. actions affect the decisions and direction of the